

WONDER DAILY

What holds a paper boat?



A sheet with a secret

Little Wonderer set a sheet of paper beside a tub. "Could this carry a penny?" Big Wonderer put down a short list of folding commands.



The folding commands

"Fold the paper in half. Fold the corners down." Little followed each command in order. More folds made an open boat with walls and a broad bottom.

Make a little book



1 Fold it into 8 boxes. Open it flat.



2 Fold short end to short end. Cut the thick line. Open it.



3 Fold the long way, pictures out. Push the ends in.



4 Fold into a book. Page 1 goes on the front!



The first voyage

Little lowered the boat into the tub. It floated: it stayed at the water's surface. The boat pushed water aside, or displaced it.



A soft ending

Later, the boat sagged. Paper's tiny plant fibers absorb water: they take it in. Wet paper grows heavy and soft until its folds lose their shape.



A climbing line

Little added a penny, then another. This load was the weight the boat carried. The boat sank lower, displacing more water.



One penny too many

"Add one penny. Watch the waterline," Little wrote. Then one more penny made the rim dip under. Water spilled inside. The boat was swamped!